

The Price of Prestige: Stress, Incentives, and Social Comparisons in Investment Banking Careers

English 201. Writing in the
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Manivannan Fall 2025 : 12/19/2025

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Research Introduction

The investment banking industry has been an alluring sector for college graduates for many decades over. Whether domestically or abroad, it has tempted prospects into joining its intense candidacy processes by the promise of early-career wealth accumulation. Its money-making potential is second to none, with hundreds of thousands to be made in one's early vicariant. When paired with the multitudes of numerical complexities fueling innovation and trade, it is an industry many find exciting. However, while its compensational structures are compelling, its human element is also a riveting factor, especially the lifestyle that promises high-stakes living similar to those in an elite society. Critically, what is often neglected is the profession's quirks that often leads to burnout.

Contemporary discourses within the investment banking workspaces are being reported at an exponential pace within different bodies and mediums of literature. Articles in different formats all cover a similar rhetoric; toxic culture within the banking world and its effects to mental health drawbacks, employee turnover, and death. Deaths have been a recurring incident within this discourse as exhaustion, lifestyle, and working hours deems this industry to be risk asymmetric to its rewards (Butcher, 2025). Additionally, whistleblower reports and lawsuits which bolster up the negative reputation of the industry's practices. On the other hand, popular digital media reinforces the luring narrative of lifestyle perks and compensational incentives. While both perspectives acknowledge the trade between work and monetary incentives, there is a gap in ongoing academic literature where other hygiene factors are neglected. Especially the link to multiple concurrent elements, from the implicit hierarchical structures, effects of digital media, and to the role of money which supposedly justifies horrid working conditions.

To address this conceptual gap, this study seeks to unpack the industry's cultural demands, and also deep-dive on fundamental problems that surround the human capital aspect. This leads to the following research questions:

1. *To what extent does the intensive working cultures and hierarchical structures within the Investment Banking field affect both the mental and physical stress of both junior or eventually senior level subordinates?*

2. *(2) To what extent do junior investment-banking professionals consider monetary incentives as adequate compensation to subject themselves to rigorous working conditions and how does this transition over time?*
3. *Can the threat of loss and exclusion, paired with the rising display of lifestyle through social media, be a driving factor in the comparative culture within junior and senior investment banking discourses?*

Through conducting a formal research process, this study aims to bridge the gap between face-value knowledge on both personal/work culture and compensation, to other notable elements. With primary research to be conducted on relevant professionals, insights should be beyond descriptive, yet nuanced to provide a cumulation of commentary from different professionals. Additionally, also adding perspective from existing academic journals available. As an early hypothesis, it is notable that cumulative lifestyle inflation serves as the backbone driver to participation in the industry. While mental and physical stress is a prevalent part of the line of work, the prestige associated, alongside current social comparisons that drive the maintenance of social status, fundamentally increases stress tolerance within this sector. A high cost of living is not only applied towards participants' social lifestyle, but also represents the tradeoff to this exclusive social discourse.

Literature Review

To answer the relevant research questions posed, and to test the integrity of the hypothesis, there were two themes identified prevalent in studying the investment banking human aspect: **(1)** *Economic rationalization of extreme working conditions within the investment banking culture*, and **(2)** *The role of money in social status, consumption, and career persistence within the investment banking field*. Both themes intersect and collaborate inquisitively in understanding the main driving factor behind the intense culture that Investment Banking is built upon. While both themes rhetorically are centered around the concept of money, they aim to investigate its effects in different regards; whether in pursuit of understanding someone's stress-tolerance in these "artificial" cultures, while considering compensation, and/or money's role in conjunction to social media in creating external drivers of career persistence. Surrounding these themes, this paper will be anchored on 6 peer-reviewed texts to showcase existing scholarship, and its eventual relevance in proving/disproving the hypothesis.

Theme 1: Economic Rationalization of Extreme Working Conditions Within the Investment Banking Culture

Culture within a financial institution, as (Thakor, 2023) studied, can be deduced by way of a Competing Values Framework (otherwise known as the “CVF”). The CVF puts into comparison a few aspects, understanding control or flexibility, and its relation to the external or internal stakeholders. It separates different cultures by its different leader types, value drivers, orientation, and eventually the theory of its effectiveness. He successfully defined and exemplified this framework into four quadrants: **(1) Clan / Collaborate** **(2) Control / Hierarchy** **(3) Create / Adhocracy** **(4) Compete / Market**, ranging from the most internally flexible, to externally authoritative. From the least extreme (collaborative); a culture that emphasizes a democratic partnership, relationship-making with external stakeholders, all the way to cross-functional teams to induce working collaboration. To the inverse of collaboration (Market / Control), where competition is encouraged, and achievement/reward is only given to those that are aggressive and hard-driving. As much as the current generation has advocated for work-life balances, the reality is that the investment banking culture is cutthroat, stressful, and will always be market-oriented. As Thakor explains his view that compensation certainly affects performance and working behaviour, but also other intangible factors matter, to see work “rewarded in terms of promotions and the granting of decision-making authority”, which utterly reinforces his theory on the CVF. Thakor also included an opposing view that with an authentic organizational purpose, driving strategy, and a new pathway of culture, there presents a chance to compensate less and still drive hard-work. Development, growth, and employee trust are also contributing factors to institutional value creation. However, there is a caveat that with an organizational purpose that also supports compensational incentive, it will probably triumph over the opposite.

Leading from Thakor’s text, it is commonly known that Investment Bankers are one of the better-compensated discourses in the labor market, particularly due to working conditions that differ from a normal 9-5. Nevertheless, job satisfaction is often on the lower end of the spectrum, with mood swings that come from unsavory work experiences, performances in the market, and/or work-related stressors. (Sobolev, 2024) provides empirical evidence of this dynamic with her study on investment banking (with focus on the trading counterparts)

compensations, and its relation to happiness/turnover intent. Throughout her study which included sampling Glassdoor reviews in relation to overall work attitudes, she found regression that suggested Beta values of different hygiene/dissatisfaction factors: whereby 0.34 β tended towards culture, 0.25 β to career opportunities, 0.22 β relating to compensation, and 0.11 β to work-life balance. The emphasis that was made suggests that culture and management contributed the most towards potential for employee turnover, and the CVF of a hierarchical “Compete / Market” quadrant may be its dominant cause. Quantitatively, her sampling of 372 reviews also suggested that compensation is the factor that people are most satisfied/dissatisfied about, with nearly 21% suggesting compensation as a workforce motivator, and 13.44% perceiving incentives as “not enough”. The second most prevalent factor would be career development, with 11.02% satisfied, and 2.96% dissatisfied. Ethics and management characteristics were also factors that contributed to general culture, whereby many noted unfairness with internal politics, authoritative control, and even a “Survival of the Fittest Culture”, further supporting the Market CVF framework. While compensation can be an incentive, ethics, hierarchical structure, and culture play an integral part to attitude/turnover, which in turn diminishes the role of compensation as a whole.

Job satisfaction is not simply a measurement or a quantitative scale, it is a visceral line which has drawbacks not only towards retention, but also in terms of effects (whether tangible or intangible). (Giorgi et al., 2017) conducted a deep dive on 20 different academic journals, and a total of 600 citation sources to eventually identify extreme working conditions in banking that ties job dissatisfaction into two factors (1) Psychological and Health Complaints, and (2) Absenteeism [measured by self reporting of days’ absence in the past year]. Its main cause is related to these stressors; workload, role ambiguity/conflict/responsibility, and lack of knowledge. High job demand as the industry deems, includes occupational stress, and eventually the listing of conflicting demands between family and work. Risk factors, from gender, to over-commitment, and responsibility, all contribute to work related stress, which in turn ends with depressive symptoms, anxiety, burnout, health complaints, visual issues, and more. As Giorgi and his peers also noted, that “a high job demand and low job control, were fingered into a limited degree in perceptions of psychological distress”, further outlining the demanding culture within banking. Throughout this study, there was no mention of compensations besides the study of redundancy, as well as the effects of a reduced salary in conflict of satisfaction. In this aspect, it ties in line on the culture perceived as “market” within the CVF, as well as sampling on work and management noted by Sobolev. Notable, Giorgi et al.’s omission of

compensation, despite the industry's fame for pay, suggests that monetary incentives come secondary when in relation to health events. Between all three studies, using Thakor's Market CVF, compensation acts as a justification mechanism, whether partial or full, against the harm of the extreme working conditions in this discourse, but does not negate adverse effects which include health, or factors including the scope of the job and its culture or environment.

Theme 2: The role of money in social status, consumption, and career persistence within the investment banking field

Millennials and Gen Z's make up a majority of today's Investment Banking human capital, particularly at a cluster we know as 'Under 36' (between the age of 24 and 36). Within the general younger generations, there has been rising concerns for burnout by way of excessive workloads, intense corporate culture, as well as a misalignment in values. For Gen Z and Millennials, there is also a high likelihood to leave their jobs due to poor work-life balance, being at 58% and 52% respectively, as opposed to older generations at 41% and 40%. Given these statistics, (Accettura et al., 2025) conducted a study on a sample of 424 U36 Investment Bankers within main financial markets of (the US, the UK, and Italy), with the goal of understanding their driving factors behind entering the industry despite rising concerns on working cultures. Results are classified into 5 clusters (1) Compensation and Flexibility (2) Skills and Experience (3) Coolness of C&IB (status and high-profile) (4) Culture and Brand Prestige, and (5) Environmental and Social Sustainability. Eventually, those 5 clusters are further deduced into 3 profiles (1) Experience Seekers at **26.2%** (those looking into status, thrill, and feeling of control) (2) Money Hunters at **17.9%** (3) Corporate & Investment Bank Lovers at **55.9%**. Given the quantitative data, money is disproven as the primary driver for entering CIBs among young professionals, with culture, status, and prestige superseding compensation. However, it is noteworthy that among those 17.9% of money hunters, 58% are over the age of 32. Suggesting that while interest reasons may differ, priority for money is dynamic and may not be the reason for entry, but may eventually be the reason for retention. The prominence of the 3rd and 4th clusters leave a clue, that as junior bankers enter the high-earning lifestyle (regardless of their motivation to enter), status upkeep becomes expensive, requiring the need to sustain lifestyle within a similar career to maintain success signals and remaining in their network of peers.

(Bartosiak et al., 2025) provides insight into how status upkeep is driven by mechanisms such as the Fear of Missing Out (FoMo), and social comparisons between peers alike which tend to be upward. To do so, a sample of 863 adults between ages 18-40 were surveyed. As explained by Bartosiak the concept of FoMo is similar to “humans hav[ing] an innate need to belong that can drive much of their behavior”. Bartosiak describes this with an example of lowered social, psychological, and financial well-being through Parasocial Relationships (PSRs), mainly as upward social comparisons become prominent, potentially driving consumption levels which hinder financial goals or plans made prior. The same concept applies in Investment Banking: junior bankers are surrounded by high-earning peers, where the pressure to keep up intensifies at each level, and consumption is constantly displayed through social media. Thakor explains that “Market” cultures drive the sentiment of heavy-competitors, not only in work environments, but in status cultures where consumption is utterly visible, and represents peer belonging or culture as they deem important. Accettura et al.'s findings demonstrate this status importance where 26.2% are status and experience seekers, which leads us to believe that at least one quarter of the entire workforce prioritize status achievements, while the 17.9% seeks money for enablement in consumption as well. This FoMo-driven mechanism reveals how financial dependencies are utterly created through their needs in maintaining lifestyle consumption with those in similar positions. Eventually, this mindset traps them in high-stress roles whereby self-actualizations are tied to social comparison, similar to a damaging parasocial relationship, which hurts social, psychological, and financial well-being.

Money is an enabler, allowing one to seek experiences and consume. Financial dependencies, as stated above, are a common syndrome many face within high-finance culture. Despite one's initial motivations of being in an institution, it can be linked by Bartosiak's and Accettura's studies that eventually, money becomes an underlying reason for retention, as well as a primary motivator in hard work. Thakor's market CVF framework also shares this sentiment, which leads us to draw the conclusion that there is a strong correlation behind competition, status, and fitting in (the inverse of FoMo), and this ties up to the concept of money altogether. (Pringle, 2025) describes this flow for six-figure+ earners as the 'lifestyle creep', where if there are progressive leaps of salary, lifestyle will follow, and so is the case within the CIBs. As Pringle says “few people forget the world of potential that opens up once you start earning”, and the fact of the matter is, no other profession earns similar wages. In a youthful and social manner, we can see status between peers - not wanting to miss out on 'luxury' that they

may afford, otherwise FoMo as discussed by Bartosiak. For mid-aged investment bankers, status changes to not only among peers, but also in a familial manner, probing the question of: 'would you still be seen the same if you cut down on your own family's lifestyle?'. Both status related concepts branch into the concept of career persistence, and how high-earners are trapped into this ever-lasting cycle of earn and spend. While the article describes the few that manage to get away from this cycle, it is statistically considered an anomaly, and many who enter this career who don't leave early on, will remain in the industry as age and experience increases. Simultaneously, delegation and hierarchy also increase, suggesting a shift in their burdens with age, and a decrease in workload which then again reinforces the authoritative culture stated in the CVF framework. As experience in the field increases, we can see a higher rearrangement to culture as well, where the enablement of 'power', as well as working conditions become much more prevalent to individuals in the industry. In hindsight, suggesting that as lifestyle inflates, so does one's authority within the firm, and that provides status which then justifies previous/current working conditions alongside monetary values, reintroducing the concept of persistence when paired with the costs of job-switching after a long career tenure.

Literature Review Conclusion

This review examined the existing literature on the Investment Banking culture within younger generations, particularly related to the aspect of money as compensation, as well as pressure from different contributing sources. To start, studies show contradicting evidence that junior bankers don't actually go into the workforce of CIBs due to allusion of money, but a majority go for passion and status. As they develop in age, compensation & financial incentives gain importance, and eventually become the primary motivator for retention within the space. In this current generation, peer pressure and the need for comparison is not only seen in real life, but also ever present within social media. Additionally, lifestyle inflation that stemmed from the need for social upkeep is also prevalent, and can initially be driven by FoMo, and eventually is driven for status upkeep within their families. The threat of de-leveling the lifestyle of those reliant on their income may be motivation enough to be subject to the vicious lifecycles of the high-finance industries, which then tames over time as their market culture wholly promotes authoritative/hierarchical leadership. The culture ingrained within investment banking is circular, reliant on experience/rank that define responsibilities, workload, money made, and eventually delegative power. Those that were once overworked, will eventually rise to the top with control

of those in similar positions, which also promotes a social sense of superiority as can be seen in these industries.

These bodies of work all conclude a similar statement, that while the initial drive of stress tolerance and 'hardcore culture' is money, this slowly shifts to cultural and social factors which come into play - supporting my hypothesis. The key to this study lies within Thakor's market framework, and how he describes culture to be within CIBs (authoritative and competitive at its core). In this case, we can see our hypothesis to evolve that cumulative lifestyle inflations are not solely material, but also correlating to the sense of importance they feel in their working environments. As an example, those working within multi-billion dollar banking projects will not feel the same degree of fulfillment working enterprise financial planning; the same analogy applies. Taking it into the context of the workforce, the active process of rising through the ranks, making more money, and delegating to more staff is all part of the reward and 'inflation' they face, and it is one they will seldom find in any other working environment. As mentioned, while there is a high cost of living in their lifestyle (namely the stress environments and constant work), there is high reward in multiple aspects being cultural, social, and financial, which ultimately becomes the primary keeper of those in the industry, and the backbone driver of those trying to advance to the next level.

Discussion

The aim of the primary interviews were to unpack relevant discourse members' opinions on key aspects that correlates to issues within the Investment Banking industry, and those that have been discussed within my literature review. Those issues pertained to the real-life problems being faced within the high-finance job scope, specific to the key topics of overworkedness, negative occupational culture, materialism, and the overall climate of the industry. Three participants coming from a banking/investment background were posed with a nine-question open-ended interview; Naman, Don, and Muhammad. In Naman's interview, he revealed a tone of engagement and calculation, where he also demonstrated awareness of the culture specifically as a junior level banker. He ultimately signaled his enjoyment of the work, alongside the advancement from someone who hasn't suffered burnout. Don approached the interview with more realism, highlighting an analytical acceptance of the industry's tradeoff and focused on financial and social validation. Lastly, Muhammad was very pessimistic throughout

his interview, showing signs of resignation toward his current situation. He noted his only goal of lifestyle maintenance and compensation, which constrains his career mobility all in all.

These three interviews were ultimately clustered under four overarching second-cycle codes:

1. Money for Lifestyle

- a. Compensation Linked Validation
- b. Burnout or Lifestyle Sacrifices

2. Comparison in Today's Workforce

- a. Physical/Social Media Peer Benchmarking

3. Costs of Doing the Job

- a. Pressure and Expectations
- b. Unpredictable and Interesting Workloads

4. Leaving vs. Staying

- a. Exit Career Motivations
- b. Culture

The crux of the interview responses pointed toward an element which partially approved of the initial hypothesis, outlining the inevitable nature of lifestyle inflation within the industry, and how that paired with the competitive banking culture, drives partial retention of the high-stressed workforce. However, the study failed to recognize a component of the key element behind said retention. The culture of the workforce that not only seemed to be a motivational factor for some in the early and late-stages of the job, but also becomes more favorable to those that turn more senior. Prestige and social comparisons within the industry also seemed to diminish after a significant period on the job, and this eventually shifts to the burden of supporting a family and maintaining levels of income that once were.

As referenced in both the Literature Review and the primary interviews, an omnipresent theme is represented by compensation and its relative impact on burnout and lifestyle sacrifices, otherwise known as “Money for Lifestyle”. Naman describes the working atmosphere within the Investment Banking industry by stating that “it’s rarely ever stress-free...really similar to an economic cycle with peaks and troughs,” an allusion that states workload intensity similar to a cyclical economic cycle, where the “bad” cycles resemble the aftermath of a recession and the “peaks” simply show comparatively calmer periods. This metaphor reveals a juxtaposition - what is defined as “calm” within the industry is not the same as “easy”, but rather tolerable in contrast

to the standard 100-hour weeks they face. This is reinforced by Muhammad's statement, "I would like some freedom and to sleep once in a while," which presents stress not as temporal, but as a constant, with diction that positions sleep (a basic human necessity) as a luxury rather than a basic human right. His tone suggests that this lifestyle is not so much a conscious choice, but more an obligation tied to one's expectations, where it is ultimately stated again with the quote, "After a while I think I wouldn't be able to continue in this lifestyle, but I end up pushing through it anyway." Ultimately, this shows both the emotions of tiredness and desperation, and if being inquisitive, a deeper reading can reveal a sense of trappedness driven by internalized social, emotional, or compensational pressures rather than a physical handcuff.

Compensation comes in as a mechanism which utterly justifies these sacrifices, as shown by Don's claim that "when my bonus wasn't great, eventually my performance was subpar for the next couple of weeks," indicating that financial rewards are not only as incentive but as emotional validation that directly influences motivation and productivity. For Don, the discrepancy between his effort and compensation received starts an internal/personal conflict, reinforcing the idea that money shapes emotional states within such work environments. To tie it all together, these narratives reveal a common rhetoric where individuals become stuck in perpetuating cycles of expectation, linking their accomplishments to ego, self validation, and the perceived necessity of sustaining an unsustainable lifestyle. Even the comparison of work intensity to a recession eventually showcases how normalized extreme labor conditions are within the CIBs, referring to compensation not as a solution to burnout but as a temporary plaster that masks the emotional toll while reinforcing the cycle itself.

Through the interviews, it is apparent that investment bankers have a strong tendency to compare and compete with one another, though some are less discerning as to the aspects in which these comparisons occur. As Don claims, "people would stay friends with each other, but ... they're competing for the same spot," while Naman reinforces this by referring to a "culture of comparison," noting that "in LinkedIn, it's very easy to see when someone gets promoted." Both statements evoke an environment similar to a shark tank, where apex performers dominate, and advancement is reserved for those deemed the "best." Rewards extend beyond hierarchy or pay to include social and emotional validation, meaning that friendship can be inferred to as superficial, fragile, or instrumental rather than genuine. The tone set above not only sets the

frame of a competitive culture, but one that fosters envy, subtle resentment, or maybe even sabotage as a result. Where most relationships persist more out of necessity than authentic alignment, and interests are only temporary and based on benefit. Muhammad illustrates a more material-side comparison, stating that “based on people’s social media posts, I can tell who was paid more than me,” echoed by Naman’s remark that “colleagues showing up with a new Rolex or a new Patek Philippe and you realize they got a bigger bonus.” These examples emphasize the ways in which status and compensation signal hierarchical gaps, with material symbols reflecting broader differences: a Rolex versus a Patek Philippe serves as a metaphorical shark versus whale, highlighting the severity of a gap within the same professional tier.

This juxtaposition implies that some bankers are much more oblivious to the extent of which the culture of competition is ingrained within themselves, whether in a material, social, or hierarchical manner. The aspect in which social media is involved may also be different, with different tools that they use to compare different aspects. For LinkedIn, it is apparent that a hierarchical comparison approach is taken, whereby people will evaluate whether one has advanced in front of them, if not hearing already from workplace chatter. On the other hand, social media tools with the likes of Instagram, TikTok, etc. are also used by both generations to display their experiences, in which social/monetary comparisons are more apparent. An aspect of retention can also be inferred for those with an ‘ingrained’ competitive culture similar to bankers within. FoMo in this case has an added element besides social/hierarchical/monetary comparisons as exemplified above, but also in strength. If we apply the same principle, it is entirely possible for those in the industry to refrain from leaving to not appear as ‘weak’, or ‘incapable’ to their peers. Thus, the topic of FoMo doesn’t just pertain to rank, bonus amounts, and/or material significance, but also in emotional endurance and perception.

A material aspect that has utmost importance in answering the hypothesis is the fourth second-cycle code, pertaining to the idea of Leaving vs Staying. This code explicitly studies the main stress-drivers within the CIB job scope, and what has prevented those within this discourse from simply leaving the environment. In the early stages of a CIBs career, many are enticed with the idea of money (be it the primary factor or the inverse). After reaching a point of time, those that are industry veterans see that culture (whether good or bad) is just as relevant

to retention, and not simply money. Going into Naman's statement of "if I reach a stage where I want a better lifestyle without sacrificing growth, that would be a key motivator", we can understand his motivation behind his career choices. Upon impasse, we may see that his motivations are simply growth and/or lifestyle, but he also implicitly considers the Investment Banking industry as most lucrative already. His diction in this example showcases his mindset that there is no better alternative of growth and lifestyle other than CIB or similar high-finance roles, which is why his tone discerns to someone skeptical. Conversely, As Don said "eventually it transitioned more into impact, and when leadership started to flow into my hands, ... work with the high-performing team and thus refining my culture", we alluded back to the issue of growth altogether. Chronologically, this as an example suggests a shift of responsibility from early-stage to mid/late-stage investment bankers, where peculiar and grunt work has passed on to the next batch of junior bankers, and the hierarchy ladder becomes more apparent. We can also note that in Don's eyes, impact is only seen once he has achieved that level of hierarchy, seemingly implying that his previous work(s) were insignificant in nature.

An allusion of a shift from the bottom to a higher part of the food chain can be deduced. Those that have once been 'overworked' will now delegate the same, lessening their responsibility. At this stage, responsibility transitions into more management from execution, and from thereon: "there really isn't any point in leaving unless it's to chase more money" (Don). This again reinforces Naman's belief that the opportunity within an Investment Bank is already at the peak, and career development is purely a matter of compensation in this case. Going back into the connotations of the text, we can sense a feeling of resignation - whereby he feels an acceptance of the situation rather than hoping for better alternatives, relating it into the fiscal motivator component. Another aspect to consider would be the exit opportunities, where it was said that "A lot of people will try to differentiate between investment banking, private equity, growth equity, VC... Eventually, they'll come to the realization that they are really just the same thing" (Muhammad). Similar to the above, we also see a component of resignation within this statement. It can be felt that they might feel "helpless" in their pursuit of growth, and they have accepted the brevity of the situation not being in their favour. This pushed to the actual reality is that the entire space of high-finance jobs are all cut from the same cloth, and moving out of this profession will ensure a cut in pay and prestige, which ultimately undermines their key motivator

besides culture, and damaging all parts of their hierarchical, social, and emotional validation source i.e. a transition to Corporate Development.

Discussion Conclusion

Overall, the interview data both supports and highlights an important gap within the original hypothesis that cumulative lifestyle inflation and social comparison sustain stress-tolerance and retention in Investment Banking. Adjacent to the hypothesis, all three interviewees articulated their beliefs that income is a strong factor to maintain lifestyle, consequently expressing their fears of “compressing what they are used to,” reinforcing lifestyle inflation as a retention driver. Similarly, the interviews extended the hypothesis in two different manners, by highlighting both the different methods for social comparison, and cultural impact within tolerance itself. For comparisons, we see this extends the hypothesis to show that; hierarchical comparisons are governed by platforms like LinkedIn, material through items with examples of luxury watches, and experiential through platforms with the likes of Instagram or TikTok. Through all methods, FoMo and competitive norms are wholly reinforced and support the content of the initial literature review. However, the findings also complicate the hypothesis such that money does not solely ensure long-term retention, but culture, authority, and managerial responsibility shifts are equally powerful motivators. Despite the meaningful insight, the study is limited by its small sample size of three participants (n=3), reliance on participants for similar professional backgrounds, and most crucially different geographic exposures. While all three bankers (or ex bankers) have had experience working in a US firm, all are situated in different places respectively, which was not taken into deep account regarding this discussion. Additionally, the interview may be susceptible to bias as the questions were touching personal matters such as compensation, status, and emotional states that might be sensitive. As a result, while data provided was nuanced, it might not fully represent the entire population of the mentioned discourse, as well as the diversity of motivations that shape entry, endurance, and exit of the industry as claimed above.

Conclusion

This study underscores the importance of how work culture, hierarchical structures, and social comparisons within Investment Banking shape both the stress-tolerance and retention of junior Investment Bankers. To begin with, we can ultimately see how fully authoritative leadership displaces 'grunt' and an unreasonable amount of work(s) within junior bankers, being part of their leadership cycle and/or transition in rank. As a byproduct, junior bankers are often coupled with high-stress due to reasons like sickness, fear of failure, and/or having their rights to sleep taken away. Monetary rewards in this case interact with other factors similar to comparisons and lifestyle expectations to reinforce their resistance, building up their capability of tolerating high-stress. However, the findings also demonstrated another focal point - that while financial incentives remain an anchor in all stages of a banker's work cycle, its significance does not remain dominant throughout the years. Cultural factors like authority, identity, impact, and belonging take precedence in long-term persistence. The synthesis extended on literature as stated above, showing that retention eventually transitions to a form of cultural inflation. What was most proven was the impact of Thakor's CVF, and how discourse members' neurotics resembled very closely to his cultural framework – of that bankers are essentially 'competition machines'. Social media in this case plays the role of a medium within these competitions, enabling for comparisons to take place in its respective aspects/platforms. Not only do bankers (whether junior or senior) compete in monetary aspects, but they do so with power as a focal topic, which eventually justifies the 'struggle' or stress throughout. Motivation is derived through status and eventually prestige, though some bankers are more oblivious to this than others.

These insights matter for a few underlying reasons; as they challenge common workplace assumptions that burnout is an economic trade-off. Instead, the interview illustrates how bankers become embedded in an ecosystem where financial need, social comparison, and symbolic power (whether through material or rank) reinforces one another. Such factors make exit not merely a career choice, but a psychological and possibly a lifestyle disruption. It could be said that lifestyle inflation in this regard is also apparent, such that no one person would like to give up their feelings of prestige or authority if it has been granted (or earned in their eyes).

Future research should not only explore this dynamic with a higher population size of junior bankers undergoing acute stages of overworkedness, but also with a goal of

understanding the different impacts of culture or geographics into the discourse. Interviewee samples should cover bankers who originate from different countries, with the end goal of seeing how traits commonly observable to their original culture can be apparent on the job, and how that might affect retention as a whole. Furthermore, to explore more in depth into the effects of the hierarchical structure within high-finance roles; ranging from its effect to retention, to comparing the culture of different workforces and its impact on the mental and physical wellbeing of subordinates. Lastly, to investigate the point in which motivations shift as bankers progress through rank, and how structural norms evolve over time. By examining these questions, industry professionals are able to deepen their understanding of why individuals remain in high-stress environments, and what reforms can reduce burnout without undermining professional development.

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